and link up with most district HQs. During a recent visit, I was happy to see the progress being made in the construction of the state legislative assembly, the civil secretariat and the housing project for the members of the assembly. These projects, alongwith the drinking water supply scheme, would change the face of Itanagar upon their completion by 2012–13. The state is eagerly looking forward to December 2012, when the railway connectivity with the rest of the country is scheduled to be established (see Sketch 35.1).

During my Republic Day speech in 2010, I made an appeal for a clean, green and plastic-free Arunachal Pradesh. I have ensured that the Raj Bhawan's people-friendly initiatives do not tread on the toes of the executive and, in fact, act as force multipliers to their efforts. Yet some may consider these steps as being proactive. For me the oath taken at the time of my swearing-in is supreme, and I believe that I am only doing my duty.

Democracy has struck deep roots in Arunachal Pradesh. The people exercise their franchise enthusiastically. Despite the allurements which various candidates promise, they generally vote for the best candidate. The fact that some bigwigs failed to get elected to the current legislative assembly is an indicator that the will of the people prevails. The message is loud and clear: the votes will be cast for someone who will deliver. Elections were conducted peacefully with impressive turnouts for the panchayat (79.16 per cent), Parliament (68.16 per cent) and the state assembly (79.5 per cent). In a poll carried out by *India Today* (27 December 2010), an overwhelming majority of Arunachalees said they were proud to be Indians, and felt that China was not justified in showing their state as part of it. It is a matter of pride for us that on 24 February 2011, Arunachal Pradesh was conferred the CNN-IBN and IBN7 Diamond State Award as the best performing state amongst the smaller states of India.

Although there are only a few hundred retired servicemen in the state, I was astonished to see that the state ex-servicemen (ESM) board was almost defunct. Hardly any of the benefits announced by the government or the ministry of defence for the veterans were